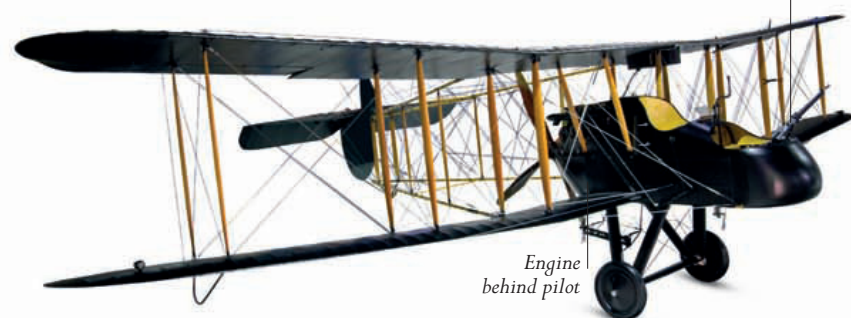


BOMBER AIRCRAFT

Aircraft were first used to bomb ground targets during the Italian campaign to wrest Libya from the Ottoman Empire in 1911, but, as World War I progressed, it became imperative to produce machines designed specifically for the task. Progress was slow, however, and even by the war's end aerial bombardment was still a haphazard affair: only what was later known as "area bombing" of built-up areas was at all effective. Large aircraft were required to carry payloads over long distances, and, vulnerable to attack by fighters, they soon began to operate under cover of darkness.



▲ RAF F.E.2

Date 1915 **Origin** UK
Wingspan 14.5m (47½ft)
Length 9.8m (32¼ft)
Top speed 145kph (90mph)
Engine 107.6kW (160hp)
 Beardmore 6-cylinder

Originally intended as a fighter, the "pusher" F.E.2 was technically obsolete even before its prototype flew, but it proved to be a success as a light bomber. Over 2,000 were built.

Wings staggered in a semi-sesquiplane layout

► RAF R.E.8

Date 1916 **Origin** UK
Wingspan 12.98m (42½ft)
Length 8.5m (27¾ft)
Top speed 165kph (103mph)
Engine 102.9kW (140hp)
 RAF 4a in-line V-12

The "Harry Tate" (rhyming slang for R.E.8; Tate was a music-hall artist) proved to be little more manoeuvrable than the aircraft it replaced (the B.E.2), but it was better armed and carried a greater payload. It remained in service until the end of the war.

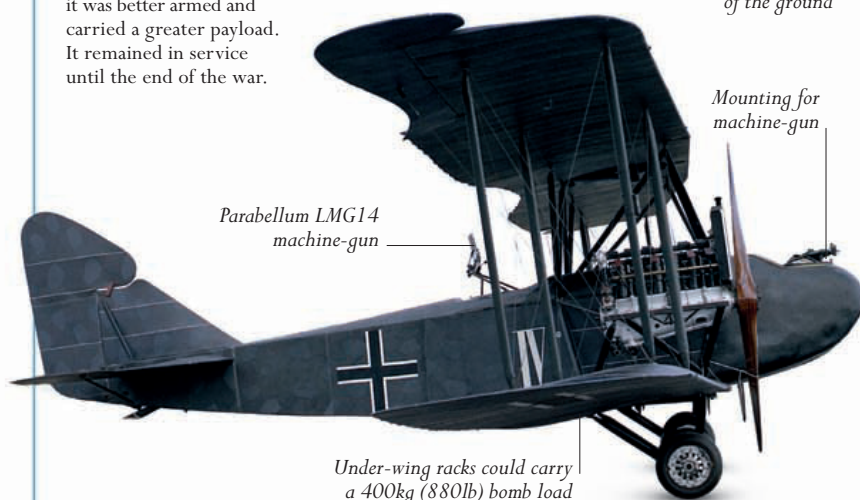


Observer had one or two Lewis guns

Tail skid

Lower wing roots cut away to improve observer's view of the ground

Mounting for machine-gun



Parabellum LMG14 machine-gun

Under-wing racks could carry a 400kg (880lb) bomb load

Enclosed flight deck, with large cabin behind



Space for crew of eight

▲ SIKORSKY "ILYA MOUROMETZ"

Date 1915 **Origin** Russia
Wingspan 34.5m (113ft)
Length 17.5m (57½ft)
Top speed 110kph (68mph)
Engine Four 108.8kW (148hp)
 Sunbeam Crusader in-line V-8s

Observer had two Lewis guns, one pointing forwards, the other up and to the rear

► VOISIN 8

Date 1916 **Origin** France
Wingspan 18.2m (61¼ft)
Length 11.02m (36¼ft)
Top speed 132kph (82mph)
Engine 161.8kW (220hp)
 Peugeot BAa in-line 8-cylinder

The French *Service Aéronautique Militaire*'s first purpose-built night bomber, the Voisin 8, was never more than mediocre, but many of its shortcomings could be traced to its Peugeot engine. Replacing it with a 220.6kW (300hp) Renault V-12 made a considerable difference.



Engine located behind pilot

Forward gun position; a 37mm cannon can be substituted for the machine-gun

Ailerons extending beyond wing-top

Bracing strut



◀ AEG G.IV

Date 1916 **Origin** Germany
Wingspan 18.4m (60¼ft)
Length 9.7m (31¾ft)
Top speed 165kph (103mph)
Engine Two 191.2kW (260hp)
 Daimler-Benz D.Iva in-line 6-cylinders

While the limited range of the G.IV meant that it was used mainly as a tactical bomber attacking battlefield targets, it was also used on the Italian front to bomb cities, including Padua, Venice, and Verona.